

SECTION-1:

Strategic Significance of Pakistan: Challenges and Way Forward

- **Abstract**

- Pakistan faces strategic, diplomatic, and economic challenges since independence.
- Located at the gateway to Middle East and Central Asia → potential transit economy.
- Geographic location offers advantages and challenges.
- Need strategies to convert challenges into opportunities and safeguard national interests.

- **Keywords**

- Strategic Location, War on Terror, Alliances, US Withdrawal, Peace and Stability, Geo-strategic, Geo-economics.

- **Introduction**

- Pakistan's geo-strategic location imposes more security challenges than benefits.
- External threat: India (increasing intensity).
- Alliances with US: Mutual Defence Assistance Agreement, Afghan war (1980s), GWOT (post-2001).
- Participation in GWOT → heavy cost, rise of intolerance and gun culture.
- Internal issues: political instability, illiteracy, ethnic diversity, population growth.
- Spillover effects of Afghan wars → economic loss, 70,000+ lives lost.

Security Challenges in a Geostategic Context

- Region is a flashpoint for great power politics for 4 decades.
- Pakistan's role: USSR containment, post-9/11 cooperation.

- US strategic interests shifted → Indo-US alliance strengthened.
 - Post-US withdrawal (2021): Pakistan faces sensitive neighborhood situation.
 - Taliban control Afghanistan but civil war risk persists due to warlords and external actors.
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War on Terrorism

- US blamed Osama bin Laden for 9/11 → Taliban refused to hand him over.
 - US/NATO invaded Afghanistan; Taliban regime collapsed in 3 months.
 - Pakistan feared US-India alliance → supported US war.
 - Hamid Karzai became interim Afghan president (Dec 2001).
 - NATO forces joined US in Afghanistan; prolonged fighting caused massive civilian casualties.
 - Emergence of Pakistani Taliban (TTP) in 2007 → major terrorist attacks.
 - Pakistan launched military operations in North Waziristan → successful but costly.
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Afghan War and Its Aftermath in Pakistan

- Opium trafficking and corruption in Afghanistan → spillover effects on Pakistan.
 - Drone strikes during GWOT killed ~2,000 people; only 3% were high-value targets.
 - UN criticized drone strikes as illegal and human rights violations.
 - Pakistan seeks peace with Afghanistan for trade and security.
 - Multilateral peace process involving Taliban and factions is essential.
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Post US Withdrawal from Afghanistan

- Taliban took control after US exit; Afghan forces surrendered.
- Stability in KPK, FATA, and Balochistan linked to Afghan peace.
- Afghan instability affects Pakistan's security and economy.

- Pak-US relations remained inconsistent; US mantra “Do More” persisted.
 - Pakistan leaned towards China due to Indo-US strategic alliance.
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Security Situation on the Eastern Border

- India links Kashmir issue to terrorism post-9/11.
 - CBMs: nuclear testing ban, hotline (2004).
 - Uri and Pulwama attacks escalated tensions; Balakot airstrikes (2019).
 - Pakistan shot down Indian aircraft; returned captured pilot as goodwill gesture.
 - India revoked Article 370 (Aug 2019) → Kashmir under lockdown.
 - Indian activities in Afghanistan aimed at destabilizing Pakistan.
 - Post-US withdrawal: India evacuated operatives; likely to support anti-Taliban forces.
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Conclusion

- Pakistan’s role critical in changing geopolitical landscape.
 - Peace in Afghanistan → economic opportunities, trade, pipelines, CPEC success.
 - Kashmir issue worsened after Article 370 revocation.
 - Pakistan needs pragmatic foreign policy, economic focus, political stability.
 - Balanced relations with China and US essential.
 - No military solution for Afghanistan or Kashmir → political dialogue required.
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SECTION-2:

Pakistan's Foreign Policy: Initial Perspectives and Stages

- **Abstract**

- Pakistan faced tough initial years post-independence.
- Joined capitalist bloc due to financial constraints.
- Security and sovereignty remained priorities.

- **Key Words**

- Alliances, Conflicts, War, Strategy.

- **Introduction**

- Foreign policy = part of national policy guiding international relations.
- Definitions by scholars: Modelski, Gibson, Frankel, Padelford.
- Core idea: achieve national interests through interaction with other states.

National Interests and Foreign Policy

- National interests = aspirations achieved via foreign policy.
- Friendship/enmity not permanent; national interest is.
- Pakistan's early interests: security and economic development.
- US interest: containment of communism → led to Pak-US partnership.

Pakistan's Foreign Policy and Indian Factor

- Jinnah's vision: goodwill, honesty, peace, UN principles.
 - India's hostility → fear complex in Pakistan.
 - India tried to undo Pakistan; wars in 1948, 1965, 1971.
 - Pakistan sought big power support (US) to counter India.
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Objectives and Determinants of Pakistan's Foreign Policy

- **National Security**

- Primary objective since independence.
- Defense against India → major concern.
- US considered favorable for military/economic aid.

- **Financial Factor**

- Pakistan economically weak at birth.
- India tried to strangle Pakistan economically.
- Pakistan sought economic ties with supportive states.

- **Ideological Factor**

- Based on Islamic ideology → close ties with Muslim countries.
- Promoted Islamic solidarity in international forums.

- **Historical and Psychological Factor**

- Bitter experience under Hindus → shaped foreign policy.
 - India's aggressive designs reinforced security concerns.
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Principles of Pakistan's Foreign Policy

- Unity of Islamic World → cordial ties with Muslim countries.
 - Good Relations with Neighbors → despite hostile India and USSR.
 - Establishment of Peace → respect for independence, non-aggression.
 - Support to Right of Self-Determination → Kashmir, Palestine, Bosnia, etc.
 - Peaceful Co-Existence → respect sovereignty, oppose aggression.
 - Cooperation with UNO → active role since 1947.
 - Independent and Neutral Policy → initially non-aligned, later shifted.
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Foreign Policy Making Process

- **Administrative Troika** → President, PM, Army Chief.

- **Ministry of Foreign Affairs** → formulates policy, coordinates with PM.
 - **Intelligence Agencies** → provide info on other states' policies.
 - **Political Parties & Pressure Groups** → influence priorities, public opinion.
 - **Role of Parliament** → debates, approves, ratifies agreements.
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Conclusion

- Pakistan's early tilt towards US due to security/economic needs.
- Need to redefine foreign policy for transparency and independence.
- Focus on economic relations over political dominance.
- Ideal policy requires political will and pragmatic approach.